

Bertrand Russell is arguably most known for his work on *denoting*, a subject that can be found “not only in logic and mathematics, but also in the theory of knowledge.” (479) When a phrase about an object is stated in a sentence, and it seems to reveal information regarding the object, this is what Russell calls a “denoting phrase”. (479) But it isn’t that easy, not quite. In fact, he states that there are three distinguishable ways in which this type of phrase can be understood: a phrase can denote an object while at the same time not denote; in a phrase, one definite object may be denoted; and sometimes a phrase can denote object(s) too vaguely. Russell focused on *definite descriptions*— cases involving ‘the’ which seem to specify a general case e.g., *the man* from *men*. With this, he has been able to further address and extend on theories from his contemporaries i.e., Frege and Meinong, showing that phrases once contradictory, can be reconstructed with a puzzle of Russell’s. In his book, *On Denoting*, Russell uses the example of a man who is also the author of a book, to highlight the importance of definite articles. It will be shown, through the use of Russell’s framework, how two different propositions can be expressed when dealing with the same object.

First we must consider our subject: Walter Scott; however, just ‘Scott’ will suffice. We are given two arguments: (a) *Scott is Scott* and (b) *Scott is the author of Waverley*. So immediately we can see that Scott is our object—he appears as himself in (a), and in (b) as the *author of Waverley*. But how can these two phrases express different propositions? Why is this even necessary to consider? Let us examine (a), as it is easier to solve than (b). Notice that the phrase simply denotes who Scott is; he is Scott. But no one ever wonders if they are themselves (unless breaching on something existential), so the statement *Scott is Scott*, doesn’t really do much for us in terms of explaining who he is per se. Moving on to (b), *Scott is the author of Waverley*, now this denotes that *Scott* is in fact *the author of Waverley*. But does this then mean

that the word *Scott* is equivalent to the phrase *the author of Waverley*? If so, this would show that *Scott* means both *Scott* and *the author of Waverley*. But how can this be? How can *Scott* have both meanings?

Following this logic, we can substitute the word *Scott* for the phrase *the author of Waverley* in argument (b) and in return we get argument (a). The same goes for switching out *Scott* for *the author of Waverley* in argument (a), we get back argument (b). So it would appear that anyone with the name *Scott* can also be called the author of *Waverley*, yet we know this is not true—have you ever called someone named *Scott*, the author of *Waverley*? How then can we set up these arguments with proper denotation? We must apply Russell's Theory of Definite Descriptions.

Look at it like building a puzzle, or better yet, taking a puzzle that has forced pieces touching, and reconstructing it into a nice, smooth work of art, with all its pieces where they should be. This will now be applied to the given arguments. Using Definite Descriptions, we see that argument (a) turns from *Scott is Scott* to *There exists an x, and x is Scott*. Now what we read is a variable, 'x', exists and that 'x' is *Scott*. Now if something else exists, say *Sarah*, then *Sarah* would not be 'x' because 'x' is assigned to *Scott*—*Sarah* can be quite literally any other letter but 'x'. Now onto argument (b) which turns from *Scott is the author of Waverley* to *There exists an x that wrote Waverley, and nothing else wrote Waverley, and x is Scott*. All definite descriptions have been replaced; notice the disappearance of the article *the*. What we now have is a statement that basically says 'x' wrote a book and 'x' has been assigned to *Scott*, so this must mean that *Scott* wrote said book. It seems more complicated than it is, overall it is a tool to help, not to make things more confusing.

To continue on the topic of definitive descriptions, we shall consider another example of two arguments (c) and (d). This can be approached just like the first question with arguments (a) and (b), the given sentences are just a bit more complicated. First, we have (c): *George IV wondered whether Scott is Scott*. Much like in question one, we have a phrase that denotes the object with a proper name that is itself—in this case, *Scott*. This makes it hard to address identity. Why would George the IV question if *Scott is Scott*? What information does he truly gain from this sentence about Scott? Given that Scott is the author of *Waverley*, it is then false to say that *Scott is Scott*, because if this were true, then Scott would in fact mean both *Scott* and *the author of Waverley*—an idea addressed in question one. Next we consider argument (d): *George IV wondered whether Scott is the author of Waverley*. So, here if *Scott* truly meant *Scott*, argument (d) would be false; but remember argument (d) is given to be true. Again, we must look to Russell and his Theory of Definite Descriptions to solve another *puzzle*.

After applying the theory, argument (c) should read : *George IV wondered whether there exists an x and x was Scott* ; and argument (d) should read : *George IV wondered whether there exists an x such that x wrote Waverley and nothing else wrote Waverley, and x was Scott*, or from an interpretation of Russell's in *On Denoting*, "George the IV wished to know whether one and only one man wrote *Waverley* and Scott was that man." (489) When we use the tools given to us by Russell, argument (c) means something different than the phrase ...*wondering whether Scott is Scott*. George IV isn't wondering if Scott is Scott; he just assumes that Scott is who he says he is. That would be equivalent to being told the name of someone all to have them present themselves with a different name than what was given. And argument (d) we can see, is true, because it relates a variable 'x', if it exists, to the author of *Waverley*, and no one else wrote *Waverley*, so anyone else that did is equal to 'x', and 'x' is Scott. This also means something

different than the original argument: it takes pressure off the name Scott to mean either *Scott* or *the author of Waverley*. By the object being assigned to a variable, and that variable being the one that wrote *Waverley*, and since that variable is Scott, then we can surmise that Scott wrote *Waverley*—different than saying ...*Scott is the author of Waverley*.